ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Great, Mighty, Awesome: How the Amidah Brings Down Blessing

Derech Hashem 4:6:11-12

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 6, paragraphs 11-12 (and the opening of paragraph 13) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 21 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Building the chain, then asking

The chapter has followed the order of the day: netilat yadayim, sisit and tefillin, and then the four parts of prayer. The korbanot were discussed at length last time, then Pesukei DeZimra, then Shema and its blessings, whose purpose is to build the chain in the spiritual world through which energy comes down. And where in the prayer do we actually bring the energy down? In the Amidah, the fourth part, which this class explains.

Three main energies (paragraph 11)

The Ramhal says there are thousands of kinds of divine influence, but three main ones. They are hinted at in the first three letters of God's four-letter name, and when all three come together, in the final hey. They correspond to the three descriptions of God in the Amidah, "the great, the mighty and the awesome", to Avraham, Yishak and Yaakov, and their completion is King David.

The Rabbi explained that this is the basics of the Sefirot. Of the ten, the main three are:

- **Hesed**, kindness, on the right: Avraham, "the great", the letter yud. "He's great, he does so much."
- **Gevurah**, strength, on the left: Yishak, din, strict judgment, "the mighty", the first hey.
- **Tiferet**, splendour, in the middle: Yaakov, "the awesome", the letter vav.

Why we need the balance

Too much hesed is not good. That is why in the Amidah we call God "Gomel Hasadim Tovim", the One who gives good kindness: some kindness is bad. The Rabbi pointed to the Torah in Aharei Mot, which calls a forbidden relationship between brother and sister "hesed": love that is good in itself, but without boundaries.

The other extreme, strict din, where everything is tit for tat, is not good either: "you live your life like that, it becomes too robotic." The balance of the two is Tiferet, splendour. Nora, awesome,

is the feeling of walking in somewhere and being taken aback: "wow, you lose your breath."

That is Yaakov. He took the good from his father and his grandfather and created his own identity; he is the attribute of truth, and truth sometimes means finding the balance. In answer to a question, the Rabbi said Tiferet is the most perfect of the three, which is why it stands in the middle.

Malkhut and the letter hey

When these three energies are drawn down properly, the result is the tenth and lowest Sefirah, Malkhut, which corresponds to King David. "Malkhut is always the receiving." The three are at the top, six permutations in between, and Malkhut at the bottom brings things to fruition: the manifestation of Godliness in this world, where it can actually be sensed.

Malkhut corresponds to the final hey of God's name, and hey is always the letter of receiving. Sarai could not have a child until she became Sarah, nor Avram until he became Avraham. The mekubalim note that Rivkah also had a hey and was able to have children. So, they write, when a woman struggles to have children, a hey should be added to her name.

The structure of the Amidah

Corresponding to these three energies Hazal instituted the first three blessings of the Amidah:

1. Magen Avraham: Hesed.
2. Mehayyeh HaMetim, which belongs to Yishak: Gevurah.
3. Kedushah, recognising something beautiful before you: Yaakov, Tiferet.

The middle blessings bring down the details of the other Sefirot. The last three blessings, of acknowledgement and thanksgiving, strengthen and fortify what has been received, so that we keep it.

So the whole prayer has a structure: in Shema we build the bridges, in the first three blessings (the most important, and the first most of all) we bring down the main energies, in the middle we draw down the details, and at the end we secure what we brought down. Really, the Rabbi added, once Yihud Hashem is acknowledged properly, everything should trickle down by itself.

Shabbat: seven blessings (paragraph 12)

The proof is Shabbat. All this applies only to weekdays. On Shabbat and Yom Tov the Amidah has only seven blessings: three at the beginning, three at the end and one in the middle, which speaks of the holiness of the day. The day's own holiness brings the energy down by itself.

The Rabbi quizzed the group: when do we say neither nineteen nor seven? Rosh Hodesh and Yom Kippur still have seven. The answer is Musaf of Rosh Hashanah, with nine, the only case where the Gemara in Berakhot asks why.

A participant asked whether Kiddush and Havdalah add blessings on Shabbat. The Rabbi answered that they do, but they are not requests; the Shabbat Amidah leaves out the requests. He gave three reasons we do not ask on Shabbat:

1. Asking for things (the sick person, the money, the deal) disturbs the tranquillity of Shabbat.

2. Shabbat is about being, not doing. The Torah never mentions the seventh day without first saying "six days you shall work", in the Ten Commandments, in Ki Tissa and in Vayakhel. In the week we strive; on Shabbat we simply are.
3. As the Ramhal says here, on Shabbat the blessing comes down by itself.

The four worlds (opening of paragraph 13)

The Rabbi began the next topic, the four worlds. Our world has two parts, the celestial (the sun, planets and stars) and the terrestrial, the lowly planet, and together they form the first world. Above it is the world of the angels, and above that the roots of the angels, discussed in Part 1, the world of the Throne. He chose not to rush it and left the rest for the next class.

Summary

- Shema builds the chain; the Amidah is where the divine energy is actually drawn down.
- The three main energies are Hesed, Gevurah and Tiferet: Avraham, Yishak and Yaakov, "great, mighty and awesome", the first three letters of God's name.
- Their result is Malkhut, King David and the final hey, the letter of receiving.
- The first three blessings bring down the main energies, the middle ones the details, and the last three secure what was received.
- On Shabbat the Amidah has seven blessings without requests, because the day's holiness brings the blessing down by itself.

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